

TORSHA CHAKRAVORTY

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Department of Economics
Pronouns: She/Her/Hers

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EDUCATION

PhD in Economics, University of California San Diego	<i>Sept. 2021-June 2027 (expected)</i>
Committee: Paul Niehaus (Chair), Julie Cullen, Karthik Muralidharan, Samuel Bazzi, Prashant Bharadwaj	
M.A. Economics, Madras School of Economics	<i>2017-2019</i>
B.Sc. Economics, University of Calcutta	<i>2014-2017</i>

AREAS OF INTEREST

Primary: Development economics, Public economics
Secondary: Applied econometrics

SELECT WORK-IN-PROGRESS

Building State Capacity in Stages: Brokers in Public Service Delivery
(with Parminder Pal Singh Sandhu, IAS)

- Job Market Paper
- Winner of Walter Heller Memorial Prize (best 3rd year paper award)

Bureaucratic processes are often completed in sequential stages whose workers are not interchangeable. Thus, the ability of states to deliver services depends on capacity at each stage of the production process. This paper tests for spillovers when the state expands capacity in only one of multiple complementary production stages. We exploit plausibly exogenous district-level variation in government staffing for routine public service applications in a large Indian state. Contrary to general intuition, citizen use of informal brokers increased in districts receiving more new workers per capita. To complement the administrative data, we collect original survey data on broker fees to quantify the de facto costs citizens face. Because informal broker roles lack standard definition, we benchmark our empirical findings against multiple theoretical models of broker competition and citizen choice. We document new broker entry, show that broker value-added persists across non-expanded production stages, and demonstrate which market structures best account for the observed price and application dynamics. Our findings illustrate the importance of understanding the organization of informal markets in the process of building state capacity.

Access or Adjudication? Allocating Capacity in Public Service Delivery
(with Parminder Pal Singh Sandhu, IAS)

Governments can expand public services by making them easier to access or by increasing their capacity to evaluate and resolve claims. This paper studies how governments allocate personnel across these two stages of service delivery. Using new descriptive evidence on the hiring of frontline and approving officials, together with a model of citizen demand and administrative congestion, we characterize the trade-offs governing this allocation. Expanding frontline capacity brings more citizens into the system, but its benefits depend on sufficient downstream capacity to process the claims it generates. The framework shows how composition of state capacity varies with demand, congestion, and the social value of access and service quality.

Highways & Innovation: Evidence from India
(with Ishani Chatterjee)

We study whether transport infrastructure affects the spatial distribution of innovation in India. Districts gaining greater access to the national highway network experience increased patenting, alongside growth in higher-education institutions and firm size. We investigate whether improved connectivity raises local innovation directly or facilitates the spatial diffusion of economic activity and knowledge.

SELECT SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

BEDI, Labor and Development Workshop University of Pittsburgh	May 2026
RIDGE/LACEA-PEG Economics Workshop on Political Economy University of West Indies, Cave Hill, Barbados	May 2026
35th Annual Conference on Contemporary Issues in Development Economics, Jadavpur University, Kolkata	Jan. 2026
20th Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi	Dec. 2025
8th Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics University of California Los Angeles	Aug. 2025
Graduate Research Workshop University of California San Diego	Apr. 2026, Nov. 2025, Feb. 2025

AWARDS, GRANTS, AND HONORS

21st Century India Center Student Research Grant	2023-2024, 2026
Walter P. Heller Memorial Prize (Best 3rd Year Paper)	2024
UCSD Winter Travel and Research Grant	2023-2024
UCSD Graduate Summer Research Fellowship	2022-2023

METHODS AND COMPUTING

Programming: R, Stata, Python (NumPy, pandas, JAX), SQL, Microsoft Excel

Methods: Applied econometrics; causal inference; instrumental variables and shift-share designs; panel and event-study methods; machine learning; analysis of large-scale administrative and transaction data; computational and numerical methods.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Associate Intern, Analysis Group

Jun.–Aug. 2025

Worked on an antitrust class action lawsuit. Reconstructed and analyzed multiple datasets using transaction-level observations. I identified misspecification in the opposing party's econometric pricing model and worked with economists and attorneys to assess its implications for the damages analysis.

Research Associate, Indian School of Business

Jan. 2020 – May 2021

Conducted quantitative research on public service delivery and institutional design. Developed research partnerships with senior government officials and established a confidential data-sharing agreement between UC San Diego and an Indian state government, providing administrative data for my current and future research.

Analytics Consultant, Data Science & AI Optimization Team, [24]7.ai

Jun. 2019 – Dec. 2019

Worked at the Data Science & AI Optimization Team. I designed predictive algorithms (using logit models and other classification techniques) for customer behavior and automated decision systems.

Business Forecasting Intern, Anheuser Busch InBev

May 2018 – Jul. 2018

Worked primarily in the Industry Forecasting team. I collaborated with strategy and marketing teams to build predictive models for beer sales in Argentina and France.

PAST TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Introduction to Social Data Analytics

Instructor of Record in SU26

Machine Learning in Economics & Business Forecasting

TA in WI25, S325, WI26

Undergraduate Econometrics

TA in WI23, SP23, FA23

Economics of Discrimination

TA in S122, WI23

Cities & Inequality

TA in S123

Last updated: September 9, 2026